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E3 Reading – Exam Prep Lesson 11: Dictionary order – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to answer all three alphabetical question formats quickly: put five words in order, circle the word that comes after another in a dictionary, and choose the correctly ordered list. This is AC4.1, the last question in each task and three easy marks if the method is secure.

Materials: Handouts 11A, 11B and 11C, one per learner. A4 card and marker pens for name cards. Paper dictionaries if the college has a class set, one per pair. A timer.

Activity 1: Alphabet speed (20 minutes, teacher-led)

1. The class says the alphabet together once forwards. Then go round the room, one letter each, as fast as possible. Time it and try to beat the time.
2. Write the alphabet across the top of the board. Draw two lines to cut it into three parts: A to H, I to Q, R to Z. Tell learners a dictionary has a start, a middle and an end. Call out ten letters; learners call *start, middle* or *end*.
3. Quick fire: “What comes after M? Before F? After S?” Learners answer chorally, then individually.
4. Learners complete section A of 11A, writing the letter before and after. Check in pairs.
5. Insist on one habit for the exam: write the alphabet at the top of the page before starting any alphabetical question. Have learners do it now on 11A.

Activity 2: Human dictionary (20 minutes)

1. Each learner writes their first name large on a card. The class lines up in alphabetical order by first name, without your help. Check the line together by reading the names aloud.
2. Where two names start with the same letter, stop and ask the class how to decide. Move to the second letter, then the third.
3. Collect the cards. Give each learner a new card with a word from one set: *station, stairs, stamp, start, stay, steal, step, stick, still, stop, story, street, strong, student, study, sugar, summer, sun*. They line up again.
4. This is hard, so let them struggle and then check letter by letter on the board, in columns, circling the first letter that is different.

Activity 3: Before and after (25 minutes, teacher-led then pairs)

1. Write on the board: *Circle the word which comes after ‘market’ in a dictionary: make, money, man.* Ask learners to guess. Many will choose wrongly, because they look only at the first letter.
2. Teach the column method. Write all four words in a column with the letters lined up. Compare letter by letter and put them in order: *make, man, market, money*. The word after *market* is below it in the list.
3. Stress the meaning of the question: *after* means later in the dictionary, lower in the list. *Before* means earlier, higher in the list.
4. Do one *before* example together with *school: shop, say, street*.
5. Learners complete section B of 11A in pairs, writing the column for each item in the margin.
6. Check on the board. Invite learners up to write the columns.

Activity 4: Guide words (25 minutes)

1. If you have paper dictionaries, hand them out. Show the two words at the top of a page. Explain that they are the first and last word on that page, and every word on the page sits between them.
2. Race: call a word. Pairs find the page and call out the two guide words. Do six words. If there are no dictionaries, skip to step 3.
3. Hand out 11B. Model the first page on the board: guide words *garden* and *give*. Test *gate*: it comes after *garden* and before *give*, so it is on the page. Test *glass*: it comes after *give*, so it is not.

4. Pairs complete both pages.
5. Check as a class. For each word ask: “Before the first guide word, on the page, or after the last one?”

Activity 5: Three formats against the clock (30 minutes)

1. Hand out 11C face down. Explain that there are three formats, as in the exam, and they have 12 minutes.
2. Remind them: alphabet at the top; columns in the margin; cross off each word once used; count the words at the end.
3. Start the timer. Learners work alone in silence.
4. Learners swap and mark as you give the answers. For any wrong answer, the marker finds the letter where it went wrong and circles it.
5. Ask for scores by show of hands. Anyone with full marks explains their method to the class in one sentence.
6. Close: “What do you write first?” “The alphabet.” “What do you compare?” “The first letter that is different.”

Answer key, Lesson 11

- **11A Section A:** L and N; E and G; R and T; I and K; U and W.
- **11A Section B:** 1 money. 2 but. 3 travel. 4 door. 5 library. 6 say. 7 park. 8 free.
- **11B:** Page 1: gas, gate, get, gift, girl. Page 2: plate, play, please, police, poor.
- **11C Format 1:** name, new, night, north, nurse. wait, walk, want, warm, water. thank, there, think, three, throw.
- **11C Format 2:** 1 however. 2 month. 3 page.
- **11C Format 3:** Question 1 B. Question 2 A.